

HOW COMMUNITIES CAN STOP DESTRUCTIVE DEVELOPMENT PROJECTS IN ARMENIA

Complete Community Opposition How-To

This guide uses the Armenian terms and bodies you'll actually run into — the environmental impact assessment and expertise, public hearings, the administrative courts, community councils and the marzpetaran, the Human Rights Defender — and explains each in plain words the first time. In Armenia the fight is usually about a mine, and underneath the mine it is almost always about water.

INTRODUCTION & FRAMEWORK

In June 2018, the communities of **Jermuk and Gndevaz** did something few thought possible: they **blockaded all four roads** to the **Amulsar gold project** — a mine roughly three-quarters built, into which a UK- and Canadian-linked company had poured hundreds of millions of dollars — and refused to let it open. Amulsar sits above the springs of a famous spa town and near the reservoir chain that feeds Lake Sevan, Armenia's great freshwater lake; the community's fear was simple and existential — the mine against the water. They held the blockade for **more than two years**. The international financiers pulled out. The town council of Jermuk voted unanimously to ban metal mining in its area. And a project a prime minister had once called almost certain to open was left frozen and unresolved.

The communities of Jermuk and Gndevaz drew on tools that Armenia's democratic opening of 2018 had sharpened. A mine needs an **environmental impact assessment and expertise** and must pass **public hearings**. It can be challenged in the **administrative courts**; protest, petition, and litigation are lawful, and Armenia is a genuine, if fragile, democracy. And — distinctively — **local self-government matters more than newcomers expect**: community councils and the provincial administrations (**marzpetaran**) have defined roles, and a community's own resolutions carry real political and moral weight, as Jermuk's mining ban did at Amulsar. But these tools have real limits, and this guide states them plainly. The win at Amulsar was a **freeze, not a permanent kill** — its future stayed contested, and in a small country with a mining-dependent economy and heavy creditor pressure, a frozen project can be pushed back toward life, so a community must be ready to defend its win again and again. That is why it helps to see these fights as a spectrum: Amulsar began with the state calling the mine certain and moved, through blockade and resistance, to frozen and unresolved — and it could move again. Read your situation as it is, and re-read it as it changes.

The Whole Strategy in One Idea

A big project looks unstoppable, but it's a chain of approvals, and a chain breaks at its weakest link. A large Armenian project needs its **environmental impact assessment and expertise**; it must pass **public hearings**; it needs the assent of **local self-government** and the land and water it relies on; it can be challenged in the **administrative courts**; and it needs public acceptance it cannot manufacture — the Amulsar lesson. Every one of those is a link you can grab. **Find the one closest to your hand and pull.**

Be Honest About Which Fight You're In

Before you spend a year on this, work out your real situation:

- **If water is at stake — and in Armenia it almost always is — that is your strongest, most unifying, most defensible ground.** Amulsar was, at heart, the mine against the water.
- **If the impact assessment is defective or the hearings were a formality, the courts and the expertise process give you grounds.**
- **If your local council will stand with you, that is a powerful lever** — Jermuk's unanimous mining ban was a turning point.
- **If the state and creditors are determined, expect a long fight and be ready to defend a win** — Amulsar was frozen, not killed.

Read the whole guide once before you move. Two habits run through it: **use the rights the law gives you** — the assessment, the hearings, local self-government, the courts — and **run every front at once**: the documents, the hearings, the council, the courts, the movement, the press. That's how Amulsar was frozen.

HOW THE SYSTEM WORKS

To break the chain you have to see it — who decides, how a project moves, and who's watching.

Who Actually Decides

A mine needs an **environmental impact assessment**, which goes through **state environmental expertise** (the ministry's technical review) and **public hearings**, and it needs mining and water-use permits from the relevant ministries. **Local self-government** — the elected **community council** and the provincial **marzpetaran** — has defined roles in the process, and a community's resolutions carry real weight. The national government and, in a mining economy, its creditors sit behind the big projects. Know which decision you can contest, and aim there — and don't underestimate your own council.

How a Project Moves — and Where You Jump In

The impact assessment and public hearings. The developer prepares the EIA; it goes through **expertise** and **public hearings**. *Your opening* — and it arms every later step: take part, put your objections — above all on water — on the record, and insist the hearings are genuine.

The permits and the local assent. The ministries issue the environmental, mining, and water permits; local self-government has its say. *Your opening*: a permit on a defective assessment can be challenged, and your council can pass resolutions that carry political and legal weight.

Construction and operation. *Your opening*: breaches, water taken or threatened — and, as Amulsar showed, sustained community resistance on the ground.

Follow the Money and the Permissions

Dig up three things. **Who's behind it and who owns them** — and, crucially, **who finances it**, because at Amulsar it was pressure on the international financiers that helped freeze the mine. **What it still needs** — the assessment not final, permits not granted, financing not secured: whatever's missing is the soft spot. **What water it threatens** — because water is the harm most felt and the ground most defensible.

Who's Supposed to Be Watching

Each is an ally or an arena. The **environment ministry and its expertise process** review the assessment and can be pressed. The **administrative courts** review the legality of permits. **Local self-government** — your council and the marzpetaran — has real roles and can pass binding-in-weight resolutions. The **Human**

Rights Defender (Ombudsman) takes complaints. And Armenia's **community movements, its environmental organisations, and a free-ish press** — reinforced by the 2018 democratic opening — are the forces that reach furthest, as they did at Amulsar.

QUICK REFERENCE: SUCCESS RATES

Size up the odds honestly. These are rough patterns, not promises. What most moves them: whether water is at stake, whether the assessment or hearings were defective, whether your local council stands with you, and how determined the state and creditors are.

What you do	Roughly works	How long	Cost	What "works" means
Just gather documents	5–10%	weeks	low	The base for everything else
Objections in the hearings / expertise	15–35%	during assessment	low	On record; conditions or a redo
Administrative court challenge	25–50%	1–3 yr	mod	Permit/assessment set aside
Local-council resolution (e.g. mining ban)	25–50%	months	low	Political/legal weight; turning point
Water-permit / water-impact challenge	25–50%	months–yr	low	Water use curbed; project stalled
Sustained community resistance / blockade	30–55%	months–yr	rising risk	Project frozen (Amulsar)
Financier / investor pressure	25–50%	months–yr	low	Money withdrawn; project frozen
Everything together (water, council, world watching)	40–65%	1–4 yr	mod	Frozen, stalled, delayed, conditioned
Everything together (state/creditor-backed)	20–45%	1–4 yr	mod	Delayed; frozen but contested

The levers that move the needle most are **water**, a **local-council resolution**, **sustained resistance**, and **financier pressure**, backed by the courts and the movement. Amulsar shows the ceiling (a nearly finished mine frozen, the money driven out) and the honest floor (a freeze, not a permanent kill, in a mining economy where a win must be defended). So aim for the full range — frozen, stalled, conditioned, delayed — and be ready to defend it.

On cost: participating, documenting, and organising are cheap; the courts are accessible; and your own council is a powerful, low-cost ally. The 2018 democratic opening widened the space — but the economy's mining dependence means a frozen project can be pushed back, so plan for endurance.

STEP 1: TARGET IDENTIFICATION

Being against "the project" is weak. Being specific — this water threat, this defective assessment, this council resolution — is strong. Answer five questions in writing.

1. What is it, and who's behind it? Name the project, the company, its owners, and — crucially — its **financiers**.

2. Where is it, and what does it touch? Get the footprint and lay it over your **water** — springs, rivers, reservoirs, the Sevan chain — and your farmland, spa economy, and land. **Water is your strongest and most unifying ground**, so map it first; Amulsar was the mine against the water.

3. What stage is it at, and what's the next deadline? Is the EIA in expertise or hearings? Have the permits issued (opening the courts)? These openings are time-bound.

4. What does it still need that it lacks? An assessment not final, permits not granted, financing not secured, local assent not given. The missing piece is the soft spot.

5. Who else is affected, and who already opposes it — including your council? Neighbouring communities, the spa town, farmers, environmental organisations — and, decisively, your local council. Jermuk's council was a turning point.

What this looks like in real life. A community learns a gold mine is planned above its springs and near the reservoir chain, with a thin assessment and token hearings. The five questions yield: a company and its international financiers; a threat to the water (the unifying ground); an EIA in hearings or permits just issued; a project still needing financing; and a coalition of communities plus a council that can act. That's the Amulsar pattern — make it the mine against the water, get your council to act, and pressure the financiers.

STEP 2: DOCUMENTATION

The difference between a community that can fight and one that can't is proof. Build it in three layers.

Layer one: the paper trail. Get the documents the decision rests on — the environmental impact assessment, the expertise conclusion, the permits and their conditions, the hearing records, the water studies. Armenia's access-to-information rights let you demand what isn't public. Then read the assessment hard for flaws — an understated impact on water, an ignored alternative, a seismic or hydrological risk brushed over, hearings that were a formality (all live at Amulsar).

Layer two: the ground truth. Dated, located photographs and video of the site, the springs, rivers, and reservoirs, the land — baseline images before any damage most of all — and the testimony of affected residents.

Layer three: the map of water and harm. Lay the project over your springs, rivers, reservoirs, and the Sevan chain, so the water threat — the heart of the case — is undeniable. Walking into the courts, or before the financiers and the press, with the assessment, the permits, and that map is what makes them act.

WHAT TO GATHER, AND WHERE TO FIND IT

- **The EIA, the expertise conclusion, the permits and conditions, the hearing records, the water studies** — from the environment ministry; force out the rest under the access rules (8A).
- **Local self-government records** — from your community council and the marzpetaran.
- **Ownership and financing** — company and, above all, financier records.
- **The water-and-harm map** — springs, rivers, reservoirs, and the Sevan chain, laid over the project.
- **Dated site evidence and named testimony** — photographs marked with date and place, and residents' statements.

STEP 3: BUILDING LOCAL OPPOSITION

Documents give you a case; people give you power — and Amulsar's blockade was pure community will. Build your coalition in four moves.

Start with a tight core. The neighbours most affected, the people who know the water and land, the spa-town community, a few tireless organisers, and respected local figures.

Win over your local council. This is Armenia's distinctive move: get your **community council** to act — a resolution, even a mining ban, carries real political and moral weight, as Jermuk's did at Amulsar. Your own local government can be your strongest institutional ally.

Build for endurance and reach the financiers. Amulsar was frozen by a blockade that held for years *and* by pressure that drove out the international financiers. Build a movement that can sustain a long presence, and a campaign that reaches the money. Hold meetings where people see the evidence — the map of the mine over the water.

Build to last, and defend the win. Armenian fights run for years, and a freeze can be reopened. Build clear roles, a secure shared archive, a way to decide together, and a plan for the financial and emotional toll — and a plan to defend a win, because in a mining economy the pressure to revive a frozen project returns.

STEP 4: LEGAL CHALLENGES, LOCAL POWER & WATER

Law and local power are Armenia's sharpest levers — and water runs through both.

Take Part First — It Builds the Record

Everything downstream is stronger if you took part in the expertise and the public hearings and put your objections — above all on water — on the record. The courts review the permits on that record, so your objections are the raw material of any challenge.

The Administrative Courts and the Expertise

If a permit is granted on a defective assessment, challenge it in the **administrative courts** by judicial review — on grounds of an understated water or seismic impact, an ignored alternative, or a faked hearing. The **state environmental expertise** process is itself a pressure point: a flawed or contested expertise conclusion (as Amulsar's was, through an independent audit) undermines the whole permit.

Local Self-Government — Your Distinctive Lever

Don't underestimate your **community council** and the **marzpetaran**. They have defined roles in the assessment, and a community's own resolutions — up to a **local ban on metal mining**, as Jermuk passed — carry real political and moral weight and can be a turning point. Getting your local government formally on your side is one of the most powerful, and most Armenian, things you can do.

The Honest Limits

Straight talk: the courts, the expertise, and local power are real levers, and water is a strong ground — but the economy leans on mining, the state and creditors push hard, and a win may be a freeze that must be defended, not a permanent kill. So use the tools — the hearings, the courts, the council, the water challenge — pair them with sustained resistance, financier pressure, and the press, and count a frozen, stalled, conditioned, or delayed project as a win, while preparing to defend it.

TURNING YOUR EVIDENCE INTO ARGUMENTS

A stack of documents wins nothing until you aim it.

Water becomes the unifying case. Not "we oppose the mine" but *"this puts our springs and the reservoirs that feed Sevan at risk — the mine against the water."*

A defective assessment becomes a challenge. *"The assessment understated the hydrological and seismic risk and the hearings were a formality — the permit is unlawful."*

Your council becomes a lever. *"Our community council has resolved against metal mining here — the local government stands with the people."*

The financiers become a target. *"The international backers are funding a mine that threatens our water and faces sustained opposition."*

Match it to the venue: the objections to the expertise and hearings; the defective assessment to the administrative courts; the local stand to your council; the water and the money to the financiers and the press.

STEP 5: MEDIA STRATEGY

In Armenia, public attention and the memory of Amulsar are real levers, and they reach the financiers where a project is most vulnerable. A free-ish press, strengthened by the 2018 opening, makes the media front central.

Lead with water and place. Not "the assessment was procedurally deficient" but "the springs and the water that feed Sevan, and our spa town's lifeblood, put at risk for a mine." Use your strongest material: dated photographs, the map of the mine over the water, community voices, and your council's stand.

Work several audiences at once — reach the money. Local and national press build the movement and pressure the government; international media and networks reach the financiers, whose withdrawal froze Amulsar. Make it easy: captioned photos, accurate summaries, a map, strong interviews.

Two hard rules. Accuracy above all — one exaggeration can discredit everything. And protect people — get legal advice before any blockade or direct action, and let the community lead its own story.

EMAILS & LETTERS

Make them your own; keep them short, exact and calm; keep a copy of everything.

8A — Access-to-information request (to the environment ministry).

Subject: Request for the EIA and permits — [project].

"We, residents of [place], request the environmental impact assessment, the expertise conclusion, the permits and their conditions, the hearing records, and the water studies for [project] at [location]. [Contact.]"

8B — Objection in the hearings / expertise.

Subject: Objection — [project] assessment.

"We, residents of [place], object to [project]: [it threatens our springs and the reservoirs feeding Sevan; the assessment understated the hydrological/seismic risk; the hearings were a formality]. We ask that the permit

be refused. [Attach evidence.]"

8C — To your community council.

Subject: Request for a council resolution — [project].

"We, residents of [place], ask the council to act against [project], which threatens our water — including, as Jermuk did, a resolution against metal mining in our community. [Attach evidence.]"

8D — Administrative court challenge (to a lawyer).

Subject: Judicial review — [project] permit.

"We instruct you to challenge the [permit / assessment] for [project] in the administrative court, on the grounds that [the assessment understated the water and seismic risk / the hearings were a formality / the expertise was defective]. [Attach the permit and our evidence.]"

8E — To a financier or investor.

Subject: Environmental, water, and legal risk in [project].

"We understand your institution may be financing [project] at [location], which threatens our water and the Sevan chain and faces sustained community opposition and legal challenge. We ask you to weigh this against your own standards. [Contact and evidence summary.]"

8F — To the Human Rights Defender.

Subject: Complaint — [project] at [location].

"We ask you to examine the flawed process for [project] and the threat to our water and rights, and [any treatment of protesters]. [Attach evidence.]"

8G — Letter to the press.

Subject: [Community] moves to protect its water from [project].

"For generations the people of [place] have lived from [the springs / the water] at [location], which feed [Sevan / our spa town]. Now [project] threatens it. We can provide photographs, documents, a map and interviews. [Contact.]"

8H — Rallying the community.

Subject: We can protect our water — here's how.

"[Project] threatens [our water / springs]. At Amulsar, Jermuk and Gndevaz blockaded a nearly finished mine, drove out its financiers, and had their council ban mining. With water on our side, our council, the courts, and the financiers' exposure, we have a real chance. Please join us. [Contact.]"

IF YOU HAVE LITTLE TIME OR FEW RESOURCES: THE RAPID-FIRE VERSION

If you must move fast and lean, do these six things, in order:

1. **Make it the mine against the water.** Water is your strongest, most unifying, most defensible ground.
2. **Object in the hearings and expertise (8B), and get your council to act (8C).**
3. **Request the documents (8A), and read the assessment for water, hydrological, and seismic flaws.**
4. **Photograph everything, with dates and places.**
5. **Get a lawyer for the administrative courts (8D), and pressure the financiers (8E).**
6. **Build for endurance, go public, and be ready to defend a win (8G/8H).** Amulsar was frozen — and must be defended.

Even lean, those six put water at the centre, engage your council, open the legal and financier fronts, and prepare you to hold a win.

WHEN THE SYSTEM IS TILTED

Armenia's tools are real, but the field can be tilted, and you must plan for it.

When the state and creditors push the project. In a mining economy, the pressure is heavy, and a freeze can be reopened. Don't fold: keep the water case, the council, and the courts alive, reach the financiers, and be ready to defend a win again and again.

When a win is reopened. This is the Amulsar caution: a frozen project can be pushed back toward life. Keep the coalition, the council's stand, and the documentation ready to redeploy.

When hearings are a formality. A token hearing is a defect — document it for the courts.

When resistance turns to blockade. The blockade was Amulsar's decisive act, but it carries real risk. Get legal advice, keep it disciplined, and protect your people.

WHEN IT'S ACTUAL CORRUPTION — AND WHO'S CAPTURED

Armenia's mining sector has real problems with the capture of permits and the closeness of powerful interests to decisions — a central issue at Amulsar — so this matters.

How to spot it. Assessments and expertise conclusions against the evidence; permits granted despite clear water risks; hearings engineered to exclude; benefits to the connected while the community carries the harm.

Who's supposed to guard against it. The **Anti-Corruption Committee** and prosecutors handle graft. The **Human Rights Defender** takes complaints. The **audit bodies** examine public money. The **administrative courts** can set aside a tainted permit, and an **independent audit** of the assessment (as at Amulsar) can undermine it. And Armenia's **investigative press**, freer since 2018, has exposed captured projects.

How to fight it safely. Document precisely and factually — how the process was bent, who benefits, what the law required — and keep clear the line between what you can prove and what you suspect. Route serious evidence to the anti-corruption bodies, the Human Rights Defender, and trusted journalists rather than making accusations you can't back. Pair the exposure with the legal challenge, the council, and the water case.

INTEGRATION & TIMELINE

Don't run these steps one after another — run them together. The documents build your proof; water aims it; your council and community build the muscle; the courts and the expertise press the case; the financiers and the media raise the cost. Together they multiply. One at a time, they stall — and remember to defend the win.

Early on (weeks 1–8): make it the mine against the water; object in the hearings and expertise; get your council to act; request the records; photograph the baseline; build your coalition and get a lawyer.

In the thick of it (months–years): challenge the permit in the administrative courts; deepen the council's stand and the expert critique; pressure the financiers; open the media front; build for endurance.

The long haul (years): carry the litigation; sustain the movement and the council's resolution; hold the line for a frozen, stalled, conditioned, or delayed project — and defend the win against revival.

FINAL ASSESSMENT

Stopping a destructive project in Armenia can be done — Jermuk and Gndevaz blockaded a nearly finished gold mine, drove out its international financiers, and had their council ban mining, freezing a project a prime minister had called certain. Hold both truths. Armenia's tools are real: an EIA and expertise process with public hearings; accessible administrative courts; a distinctively powerful role for local self-government; a strong water-based ground; and a democratic opening since 2018 that widened the space. And the constraints are real: a mining-dependent economy, determined state and creditor pressure, and wins that are often freezes to be defended rather than permanent kills.

Here's the discipline that wins. Make it the mine against the water — your strongest, most unifying, most defensible ground — and pry loose the assessment and the permits. Object in the hearings and expertise, get your community council to act (even a mining ban), and challenge a defective permit in the administrative courts. Build for endurance, pressure the financiers whose withdrawal froze Amulsar, and carry the story to the nation and the world. Count a frozen, stalled, conditioned, or delayed project as a win — and be ready to defend it, because in a mining economy the pressure returns. That's what Jermuk and Gndevaz did — the water, the blockade, the council, and the money, together. So can you.